> Peace—or we remain on the borders we attained in the war. We mustn't intertwine, certainly not at this point in time, ahead of the first discussion in the UN, other issues, including the refugees. . . . As for the refugee problem, responsibility for the Arab refugees, both in the Gaza Strip and the West Bank, will remain in the hands of UNRWA, in accordance with the agreement reached between the Government of Israel and UNRWA representatives. This was a tremendous achievement for us, for UNRWA to agree to continue to take this issue on as its responsibility. Here we are, twenty years after the War of Independence, and we have ceased to be responsible for this matter called the refugees. . . . UNRWA is formally responsible for them. God forbid should we try to change one thing about this arrangement and accept responsibility while there is no solution, when UNRWA is agreeing to continue to bear this responsibility.

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Whoever came up with the idea of a special refugee agency for the Palestinian refugees, whoever conceived of the notion of subordinating this agency to the UN General Assembly, whoever formulated the definition of Palestinian refugeehood, whether it was one person or the collective brainchild of a group of people—was a genius.

In 1949, it would have had to be a genius, with the ability to see into the future, to construct a diplomatic architecture that would perpetuate a conflict between two peoples. The reader may glean that according to my analysis, in the eyes of the Arabs at the time, the conflict was and would always be a zero-sum game. First, they defined their defeat in the War of Independence as "Nakba," which was the associative counterpart of the Holocaust, and by doing so attempted to create a conceptual symmetry between the two peoples—the Jews and the Palestinians. The connotation of such an association was that if the world saw the Holocaust as a reason and justification for a Jewish state, then it must recognize the need to establish a Palestinian state after the "Nakba." And since the two peoples had claims over the same territory, and in the first round of the war over this territory the Palestinians lost, it was necessary to build a mechanism through which the Palestinians' "War of Independence" could be extended until they could claim victory. And the victory, according to the Palestinians, was the elimination of Jewish existence in the Land of Israel and the establishment of a Palestinian state on its ruins. The mechanism that the Arabs built was UNRWA, together with a definition of Palestinian refugeehood that was different from that of all other refugees of all the wars that had taken place on the planet since World War II. Later, beginning in the early 1960s, when an independent Palestinian national consciousness